cumin seeds. There would have been various kinds of kebabs and perhaps even sanbusa (samosa), or qutab as it was called in Turki. There would almost certainly have been pilau, a Central Asian speciality cooked in oil from the fatty tails of sheep, as described by a mid-nineteenth century European traveller:

> A few spoonfuls of fat are melted…in a vessel, and as soon as it is quite hot, the meat, cut up into small pieces, is thrown in. When these are in part fried, water is poured upon it to the depth of about three fingers and it is left slowly boiling until the meat is soft; pepper and thinly sliced carrots are then added, and on top of these ingredients is put a layer of rice, after it has been freed from its mucilaginous parts. Some more water is added, and as soon as it has been absorbed by the rice the fire is lessened, and the pot, well-closed, is left over the red-hot coals, until the rice, meat, carrots are thoroughly cooked in the steam. After half an hour the lid is opened, and the food served in such a way that the different layers lie separately in the dish, first the rice, floating in fat, then the carrots and the meat at the top, with which the meal is begun.

Rather than this hearty recipe, the pilau cooked would have been the more refined Persian variety, developed under the Abbasid caliphs of Baghdad. Food historian Lizzie Collingham writes that the highly aromatic dish was cooked using numerous additions: ‘fruit pilaus, turmeric and saffron ones, chicken pilaus for special occasions; some varied by the addition of onion and garlic, or with raisin and almonds, and others varied by the color of the rice’. Since barley and wheat were the crops of Persia, and rice a luxury from India, this dish grew as a way in which to make this expensive main ingredient a centrepiece of the meal, not simply a side dish.

The women gathered in the gardens of Bega Begum, Humayun’s first wife, resilient and outspoken and the most senior of the Mughal women as Khanzada Begum had recently died, and decorated the place in a ‘new fashion’ according to Gulbadan, possibly inspired by Hamida Banu’s long sojourn in Persia. Even the food they now ate may have had a fragrance of the great banquets Hamida Banu and Humayun had enjoyed in Persia, where they had been feted with ‘fine sherbets of lemon and rosewater, cooled with snow…preserves of watermelon, grapes and other fruits, with white bread’.